

S02-L3 — Living Contemporary Artists: How to Read the Revaluation of a Market Still Under Construction

Summary

Today's lesson compares two contemporary artists with recent presence in Phillips' New York sales, Derek Fordjour and Firelei Báez, to illustrate the difference between an isolated auction result and a price record that holds up across multiple houses and seasons. The first shows two consecutive sales, at different houses and two years apart, with the price rising each time. The second shows her own record beaten the same day by a rival house, illustrating why a single high result is not enough to call something a trend. The note closes with the concept of "wet paint," the resale of recently made work shortly after it leaves the studio, and with the broader picture of women and Latin American artists that Phillips has been placing in its Modern & Contemporary Art sales between 2024 and 2026.

1. Why a market still under construction reads differently from a settled one

When an artist has been dead for decades, the auction record can be reviewed backward across generations, and a new result gets measured against a wide universe of prior data. With a living, actively working artist, that universe is still being built, so each new sale carries proportionally more weight on the reading of the market than it would for a historical master. The relevant question stops being "how much did this work sell for" and becomes "how many times, at how many different houses, has a similar price level been confirmed." That repetition, not a single sale, is what separates a real track record from a one night coincidence.

2. The Fordjour case: two houses, two years, the same direction

Derek Fordjour, an American painter known for his work in collage and burlap over sports and crowd scenes, shows the cleanest pattern currently available in Phillips' recent catalogue. [Phillips sold his work *Numbers* for USD 889,000 on](#)

[May 14, 2024](#)¹, and on November 19 of that same year placed *Twelve Tribes*, this time for [USD 1,143,000, twenty percent above the artist's previous record, set at Christie's on May 13, 2022 at USD 945,000](#)². Two different houses confirmed the same price direction within a two year span, which the house's own internal research classifies as a "recent edge" still standing at the time of this lesson.

3. The Báez case: one high afternoon and the limit of reading it as a trend

Firelei Báez, a Dominican painter based in New York known for portraits that blend colonial Caribbean cartography with plant and textile motifs, provides the necessary contrast. [Phillips sold *Daughter of Revolutions* for USD 645,000 on November 19, 2025, then beating the artist's previous record](#)³. However, [that same day Christie's placed *Untitled, Colonization in America* for USD 1.11 million, far above the result Phillips had achieved just hours earlier](#)⁴. The day's highest benchmark ended up at a different house, and there is not yet a second result confirming whether that level holds. The correct reading is that Báez's market is at an earlier stage than Fordjour's, not that it has less future ahead of it.

4. The "wet paint" risk

Trade jargon uses the term "wet paint" for a work that returns to auction very soon after leaving the artist's studio, sometimes with as little as a year or two in between. The risk is not in the price of that particular resale, which can turn out well, but in treating it as proof of a consolidated market when there has not yet been time for several buyers, at several houses and over several seasons, to confirm the same level. Neither Fordjour nor Báez is a wet paint case in the strict sense, both have more than a decade of active careers behind them, but the reading mechanism is identical to the one that would apply to an artist fresh out of an MFA program, repetition over time and across different houses is what separates a confirmed price from a still speculative one.

5. The wider picture: women and Latin American artists in Phillips' sales

The Báez case is not isolated within the house's recent catalogue. In the same 2024-2026 window, [Phillips set Olga de Amaral's record at USD 1,168,400 with *Imagen perdida 27* on May 13, 2025](#)⁵ and then [placed *Umbra E* for USD 1,677,000 on May 19, 2026](#)⁶, before [Christie's took *Pueblo H* to USD 3.12 million on November 19, 2025, roughly one hundred and fifty percent above Phillips' May record](#)⁷, repeating exactly the pattern now seen with Báez. That same May 2026 sale added [Beatriz Milhazes with *Paraty* for USD 516,000, Adriana Varejão](#)

[with *Monocromo redondo Guan* for USD 361,200, and Carmen Herrera with *Blanco y Negro* for USD 322,500⁸](#), a set that shows the house building, season after season, a catalogue with more than one Latin American woman's name in its upper Modern & Contemporary Art range, even though each individual name still requires the same analytical care applied to Fordjour and Báez before calling it a consolidated trend.

For the client conversation

When a client asks whether it's worth buying a work by a living artist whose price rose at a recent auction, the first useful question is how many different houses and how many different seasons confirm that level, not how much it sold for last time. A track record like Fordjour's, with two houses and two years pointing the same direction, supports a price conversation more solidly than an isolated result like Báez's, without that meaning the work should be discouraged, only that caution is warranted about the level to pay. Faced with a "wet paint" offer, very recent work presented with a promise of a quick resale, the professional recommendation is to ask for that artist's resale history at more than one house before treating the first high sale as a guaranteed floor.

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1. Phillips, "Derek Fordjour," artist page. phillips.com/artist/14205/derek-fordjour. ↵
 2. HENI, "Derek Fordjour, Twelve Tribes," November 19, 2024. heni.com/news/article/derek-fordjour-twelve-tribes-2024-11-19. ↵
 3. Phillips, "Firelei Báez," artist page. phillips.com/artist/14295/firelei-baez. ↵
 4. HENI, "Firelei Báez, Untitled, Colonization in America," November 20, 2025. heni.com/news/article/firelei-baez-untitled-colonization-in-america.... ↵
 5. Phillips, "Phillips Sets Five New Artist Records in Evening Sale of Modern & Contemporary Art," press release, May 2025. phillips.com/press/release/phillips-sets-five-new-artist-records.... ↵
 6. Phillips, sale catalogue NY010326, May 19, 2026. phillips.com/auction/NY010326/browse. ↵

7. HENI, "Olga de Amaral, Pueblo H," November 20, 2025. heni.com/news/article/olga-de-amaral-pueblo-h-2025-11-20. ↵
8. Phillips, sale catalogue NY010526, May 2026. phillips.com/auction/NY010526. ↵